

Hypsiphrone

Codex Reference: XI,4

Translated by: John D. Turner

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by John D. Turner

Hypsiphrone, which means “high-minded one” or perhaps “she of exalted thought,” is the fourth and last treatise of Codex XI of the Coptic library from Nag Hammadi. It presently consists of four large and two small fragments containing the lower portions of the inner and outer margins of two papyrus leaves, which must have originally contained the entirety of this short treatise. It is written in the same script as the much longer and better preserved treatise of that Codex, *Allogenes*, although there is no discernible further relationship beyond these two treatises. Hypsiphrone is written in an apparently standard Sahidic Coptic dialect, unlike the other treatises of Codex XI. It bears the superscript title “Hypsiph[frone],” the remainder of the title being restored from other occurrences within the treatise; since the conclusion of the treatise is not extant, it may or may not have borne a subscript title.

Apart from the poor condition of the treatise, even its cryptic title affords little insight into its content. The incipit “The book (or scroll) [concerning the things] that were seen [by] Hypsiphrone being [revealed] in the place of [her] virginity” adds little more. Although there is mentioned a plurality of persons speaking with one another, the treatise does not appear to be a dialogue. Instead, the whole is presented as a speech of Hypsiphrone who reports the receipt of certain revelations during her descent from the “place of her virginity” into the world. The only figure mentioned by Hypsiphrone is one Phainops, “he of the gleaming eye,” who apparently presides over a fount of blood into which he breathes, and which seems to produce a fiery effect.

One may conjecture that Hypsiphrone represents some form of the personified thought of a high deity who leaves her dwelling in the transcendental realm, where there are no distinctions of gender, to descend to the earthly realm at the time of the creation of humankind. There she encounters Phainops, probably in the act of creating humankind, who apparently produces “a [man in the likeness] of blood” from his fiery fount of blood.

In spite of the paucity of text, what remains seems to have some affinity with the group of gnostic texts generally designated as Sethian. To judge from the name Hypsiphrone, one may have to do here with the Sethian figure of Eleleth, called Phronesis in *Hyp. Arch.* (93,8-97,21), one of the traditional Sethian Four Illuminators, whose name might be derived from Aramaic *‘illith*, “the tall one,” which could be rendered by Greek *hypsiphrone*.

The fount of blood may refer to the heavenly Adamas or heavenly archetype of Adam, described in *Orig. World* (108,2-31) as the “enlightened bloody one” (based on the Hebrew pun on *adamy* “man,” and *dam*, “blood”). In this case, Hypsiphrone would be the Illuminator Eleleth, who in some Sethian texts is regarded as the abode of Sophia and certain “repentant souls” and in others (*Trim. Prot.*, *Gos. Eg.*) is held responsible for the act usually ascribed to Sophia: that of produc-

ing the demiurge Yaldabaoth. Eleleth/Hypsiphron would also be responsible for the projection below of Adamas, the image of God after whom the earthly Adam is modeled. In any case, Hypsiphron is certainly a figure similar to that of the descending and restored Sophia. Phainops, “radiant-faced one,” might then be a name for either the enlightened archetypal Adamas, or, since he seems to be distinguished from the “fount of blood,” for the fiery angel Sabaoth, the brother of the evil demiurge produced by the breath of Zoe, Pistis Sophia’s daughter, in an effort to imprison the demiurge (*Hyp. Arch.* 95,5-96,4). Thus, although it bears no trace of the traditional Sethian names for these figures, Hypsiphron may in fact be very closely related to the other Sethian texts.